

# In Honor of the Earthworm: Pockets of Air for “Decolonial Riders” and Activist Literacies in White Settler Writing Programs and English Departments

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*ABSTRACT: White settler logics show up so deeply in the dailyness of writing programs (especially when housed in English departments) that it blocks our programs from even coming close to reaching equity, antiracist/anti-colonial pedagogy, or even basic, justice-based approaches to writing. In this essay, I offer an endarkened feminist narrative of such white settler workings while I simultaneously position undergraduate students who write and create their own activist literacies as what la paperson calls “decolonial riders.”*

*KEYWORDS: anti-colonial pedagogy; Black intellectual counterlife; Black rhetorics; disciplinary whiteness; endarkened narrative*

After working as a writing program administrator (WPA), I was at my wit's end and couldn't wait to get back into the classroom. In one job interview for a non-administrative faculty position, the hiring committee consisted of both literary-focused and rhetoric-focused faculty, all of whom were white. A white woman asked me how I would adjust to teaching. I was baffled by the (HR-noncompliant) question directed so specifically and aggressively at me. She had obviously researched my time at my previous college, but she didn't fully understand my role there. I was not in a 50% teaching + 50% research position because I was a WPA. The interviewer must have read the confusion on my face because she then gave me very basic information about what it was like to teach multiple sections of first-year writing as if I wouldn't know and hadn't done this my whole career (and just a few train stops away from her at a neighboring school at that). I was annoyed because the kind of teaching the interviewer described was not something the interviewer had ever done herself while my CV provided evidence of multiple such teaching experiences, many times over (after all, I looked her up too as any good interviewee does). My response was simple: “Well, I’m a

WPA. That's much harder. Your teaching load would be much lighter work than what I do as a WPA right now because I'm the one making sure you get it right." It was seriously the first, honest answer that came to my mind. One of the members of the committee, a rhet-comp person, spit out his water. He was trying to laugh but the choking coughed him up too much. He seemed surprised that I would put it out there like that. I really wasn't trying to be contentious (though certainly a little stank-attitude-esque). I was just stating a fact to someone who didn't know better than to ask such dumb questions out loud and to be so non-compliant with the basic hiring protocols of a public institution. What you NOT gon do is school me on my own discipline when you ain't learnt and have no business on a hiring committee anyway.

I am not someone out here cheerleading for rhetoric-composition studies, because I don't bow allegiance to any western discipline, especially when academic disciplines have offered so little epistemological and political challenge to anti-blackness. Ain't no allegiance to Black folx in these PWI-university streets and so I have none to give back. Black feminist praxis teaches me that many things can be true at the same time though (Davis et al.). I can question and rupture the boundaries of western disciplinary confinement in and out of rhetoric-composition studies. I can check someone who paternally/maternally denigrates my discipline and the classroom work that I love. I can full-body whatever fool thinks they can disrespect the body that I do this work with. I can hold onto righteous rage and refuse the white supremacist requirement that I simply forget and co-sign past harms. That's how a Black feminist shows up to rhetoric-composition classrooms, interviews, department meetings, and the institutional hoops and closed doors of our universities.

I suspect that I went from a look of consternation at this interview to one of sheer annoyance (I don't usually fake the funk). *Who is this fool interviewing me who doesn't know jack about rhetoric-composition studies in the 21st century?* Why yall even allow this mess? Today I know that such interview experiences are a sure sign of bigger problems under white settler colonization and the specific ways it targets rhetoric-composition programs. I have

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come to expect this now, but I have never adjusted to the ways that rhetoric-compositionists are so complacent about the white colonization of writing instruction while proclaiming a commitment to democratic classrooms and progressive pedagogies.

Today I am ashamed to admit that I often referred to compositionists who do not challenge their harmful colleagues and racist structures in English departments in a very negative way: as worms. No courage. No spine. No ability to stand up anywhere. Just worms squirming along. I regret talking this way now, not about compositionists, but about worms. My ableism meant that I had pejoratively associated weakness with diverging spinal function, thereby incorrectly and offensively marking resistance as able-bodied. A lie! I should have known better than to talk that way! My total lack of eco-consciousness and relationality further meant that I also dismissed earthworms who have a very vital ecological role. As someone who likes to garden, I take great care of the earthworms who cross my path. And as someone relatively new to Texas, where I now live, I scream for joy and offer motivational mantras to every worm I meet since the dense clay soil here prevents their livelihood. Yes, I talk to worms cuz this life right here in Texas is hard-earth. Literally and figuratively. In ways seemingly unrivalled by anything else, my miraculously flexible friends redistribute all kinds of organic matter as they open pockets of air for everything that comes near them. They decompose and aerate everything in their pursuits of original pathways that, in turn, help everything that they touch. I owe the beauty and sustainability of my garden to earthworms. We would be blessed to have rhetoric-compositionists like that, and I should never have suggested otherwise. Our discipline would be transformed if we all behaved like earthworms. I realize that I am making some serious allegations that might offend many, because of course, it is sometimes easier to criticize my “wild accusations” than the actual goings-on of one’s own institution. But I have seen some things and plan to pour that tea here.

White settler logics show up so deeply in the dailyness of writing programs (especially when housed in English departments) that it blocks our programs from even coming close to reaching equity, antiracist/anti-colonial pedagogy, or even basic, justice-based approaches to writing. And while justice might not be very many scholars’ goals, they should at least acknowledge that an acquiescence to and ignoring of the white supremacist workings of professional settings can never result in democratic classrooms, especially those including BIPOC. In this essay, I offer an endarkened feminist narrative of such white settler workings while I simultaneously position

undergraduate students who write and create their own activist literacies as what la paperson calls “decolonial riders.”

### **Black Feminist Storymaking as Methodology**

The tea spilled in this essay flows as an endarkened narrative of the white settler colonial occupation of rhetoric-composition programs. My notions of “endarkened” come from Black feminist thought, most notably Cynthia Dillard’s now 25-year-old treatise, “The Substance of Things Hoped for, the Evidence of Things Not Seen.” As a challenge to the Enlightenment-born philosophies that nurtured western Europe’s colonization and enslavement of the rest of the world, Dillard proposed “endarkened” work. For me, endarkened politics deliberately challenge western Europe’s narrow, exclusionary definition of humanity that is foundational to the humanities and social science regimes of the university (Jackson; Wynter).

As an endarkened narrative, I also think in terms of Black narrative sequencing as it was theorized by Geneva Smitherman in 1977 (Redd). Central to Black Language, narrative sequencing is not merely counter-institutional critique. It is also wedded culturally and psychically to Black life and survival (Baker-Bell). Black narrative sequencing relies on multiple, meandering stories—not a singular and controlling storyline—that take you to and through complicated experiences. It commits to a non-linear understanding of time where the Black past, present, and future are always wedded (Thomas). No singular story exists without the meanings of the others and thereby allows for a fuller sense of Black life and literacies. Narrative sequencing is more than just a writing method, but a way for me to access and verbalize the institutional politics of race, anti-blackness, and misogynoir that might otherwise destroy me.

Black Language’s narrative sequence and Black feminism’s endarkened philosophies provide access to what I call Black feminist storymaking (Kynard, “Oh No”). I thereby inherit the language and wherewithal to understand and critique white settler themes that have confronted me at each and every institution where I have worked: Black college, MSI, HSI, PWI; urban and suburban locales; private and public schools; wannabe R1, social-climbing R2, down-and-out comprehensive, or white-canon-loving liberal arts institutions. Every single place promised new, exciting changes. They all said new possibilities were coming. Each and every time. Everywhere. But I stay like Cardi B when it comes to all these claims and promises of transformation and simply retort: *“how come I ain’t seent it yet?”*

**“And If Ya Don’t Know, Now Ya Know”**

White settler logic may be ubiquitous, but so is resistance and defiance to it. There ain’t never been one without the other and certainly not in classrooms. White supremacy has never won, otherwise it wouldn’t need to keep unleashing suppressive tactics. As theorists like Ngũgĩ wa Thiong’o, Tsitsi Dangarembga, Aimé Césaire, Cheikh Hamidou Kane, and Walter Rodney have always shown us: the irony and contradiction of colonial schooling is that it also produces students who strike the empire back. This is the crux of how la paperson defines “decolonial riders” and how I locate activist literacies therein. From the moment BIPOC students entered American universities, they have connected oppressions on-campus with off-campus social realities and have protested and challenged every hierarchical regime (Kynard, *Vernacular*). The newest architectural structures of so many universities are now built with student defiance in mind where top administrative buildings/offices/floors are inaccessible, locked up, and hidden far, far away. They know students are eventually coming for them.

Students’ activist literacies are also lodged in the everyday life of classrooms. These are the moments of personal insight, multimodal design, and cultural-rhetorical impact where students are actively, creatively, culturally, and deliberately building a race-radical critique against the whiteness of the institution that is holding them captive. I center race-radicality in this equation because challenging the American university must mean situating its problems in white supremacy, plantation histories, and land-grabbing (Grande; Dumas; Boggs et al.). This everydayness expands the notion of activism past marches and public protests. For students who are caretakers of multigenerational families, disabled, food-insecure, unhoused, or just plain ol’ tired, tired, tired, the notion of activist literacies must be expanded beyond campus protests. By the same token, I am challenging the supposed radicalness of those students marching and chanting up the block but sliding back to class insisting that they are equally radical when their schoolish essay writing is locked into European argument styles and white standardized English.

I can never anticipate exactly how activist literacies will look in my classes in any given semester. I just know to look. Haven,<sup>1</sup> a young Black woman organizer who has now graduated, is the student who helped me see and understand one particular university where I have worked most clearly. She was BIG MAD that her senior year of college was the first place where she learned about Black rhetoric and Black Language as a writing/rhetoric major.

This is a typical reaction that I experience from students every semester, but Haven gave the chronicle of her anger a name in a project that I love: “‘And If Ya Don’t Know, Now Ya Know’: Black Rhetoric and Language and the Politics of Educational Withholding.” This was a multimodal project named with a popular line from rapper, The Notorious B.I.G. AKA Biggie Smalls. Haven shared this project with her classmates that featured her own artwork, quotes from her favorite Black rhetoric and Black Language scholars, as well as videos, gifs, speeches, and music videos that set the critical context of Black rhetorical study in white supremacist schools. In “‘And If Ya Don’t Know, Now Ya Know,” Haven calls Black Language and rhetoric her “comeback from educational withholding” and thus offers a clear charge to language teacher-scholars: an intersectional, antiracist classroom cannot withhold Black people’s language and rhetorics from them and imagine itself to be on the side of freedom. I immediately loved this coinage of educational withholding and wanted to know how Haven knew so much about the Notorious B.I.G. because she wasn’t born yet when he made the song. This was largely a distraction to the work at hand, so Haven ignored me and stayed focused while I fancifully imagined her first words as an adorable toddler coming from Biggie’s lyrics. I had a good time. Haven may have had fun too, it’s hard to say, because she did not come to play: she was the one who started putting the university’s diversity initiatives on full blast in the course, a process that her classmates pursued the entire semester. I mean they named the names and gave me an introduction to the department and the school that I have never forgotten.

Haven kicked open the door with this first project of the semester and it stayed poppin from there. She locates schooling and the way it practices language education as part of the way that it enacts racism, anti-blackness, and colonization (Baker-Bell). In the class where I met her, my students and I study the ways that Black Language is a rule-governed system. I won’t spend time on these linguistic facts here, since Black linguists have covered that so much better, but we must understand that this grammatical system is hundreds of years old (see John Baugh, the Rickfords, Lisa Green, Samy Alim, and Elaine Richardson). So when I routinely say things like: *she be gettin on my last nerve*—I can trace that back to my ancestors across centuries. This is called Habitual Be and it is a tense not found in standardized, white mainstream English. Understanding the rules of Habitual Be or even removing it ain’t hard, but you must ask yourself why Black people would still incorporate this Africanized verb tense into their language after hundreds of years. Why would we choose white language over a defiant Black legacy like that and

act as if whiteness has ever done anything radical like that? The math ain't mathing. Haven started asking the same questions.

I met Haven in an upper division rhetoric seminar at a PWI in the south with eighteen other students where seven of the students were BIPOC women. I hadn't developed any real bonds with colleagues yet since I was still in my first year there, and the earful that my undergraduate students gave me has tainted that possibility for years to come. At one point, I even had to ask students to stop saying folx's names and explained compliance issues to them just to keep us all safe. Inspired by Haven, the BIPOC women dragged one white faculty member so completely that it hurt even my feelings even though I had only ever said hello to this person once in the hallways. As it ends up, their critiques tracked well with the college-wide NSSE data that I saw many years later where BIPOC students reported getting "diversity-related" content outside of classrooms, not from their course curriculum; meanwhile white students reported that they did not seek "diversity"-related activities outside of class and did not feel prepared to address DEI issues in their professional and personal lives after graduation. This was readily accessible data and yet no one in the writing program or department ever discussed it. There was no real need to remove DEI, as is the national tenor, since it wasn't there to start with. Such DEI initiatives have been largely removed across the country now, but they were never antiracist, radically inclusive, or transformative in the first place.

Many years prior to the dissemination of this easy-to-believe data, the major beef of the young BIPOC women in Haven's class was that many of the majority-white faculty left it up to them to challenge racist students while faculty said and did nothing and, in sum, profited from the labor of BIPOC students in their classrooms. Many faculty even comforted and supported white students in their racist or race-limited understandings. These young BIPOC women undergraduates described themselves at length as having to teach faculty's classes for them when it came to the so-called "diversity" topics. As far as Haven was concerned, she was the DEI content and had a more sophisticated background knowledge than the faculty. Imagine then my astonishment when in that same semester, an instructor who talked quite passionately about how she preferred teaching upper division courses because the students were so much more receptive to her DEI visions ended up being the exact same person Haven and her peers shouted down and dissed like a bitter regret every week in my class. Like Sara Ahmed reminds us, DEI was never radically oriented anyway so the stakes are really low here, but even the lowest stakes were out of reach as far as Haven and her

classmates were concerned.

The focus of that course was an advanced seminar in Black rhetoric called *WORD IS BOND: Black Language and Rhetoric* (see [funkdafied.org](http://funkdafied.org)). On the one hand, it might not make sense for students to be going to town like this given the course topic. But that's just the thing. You can't have young folx reading and studying the rhetoric of someone like Maria Stewart telling them "Why Sit Ye Here and Die?" and think they ain't gon apply that up and down and all around in very real-life ways in every class discussion and in every writing/composing/design assignment they can. As far as many of the students were concerned, if Maria Stewart was sayin this stuff back in the 1830s, then why can't white faculty almost 200 years later get it together enough to offer just basic inclusion? And that was the question from the white students who were just as ready to go there as the BIPOC students. If you are standing against a colonial approach to schooling, then you will land right in the middle of an anti-colonial critique of every micro-working of your school. I never asked students a thing about the college, school, or department. I do, however, place race-critical personal experiences right alongside historical events and published theory in my pedagogy. Students' embodied experiences of racial oppression is as theoretical and academic as the readings I assign.

Interactions with students that deconstruct the colonialism of their classrooms, teachers, and schooling are central to the work of an anti-colonial pedagogy and are the bedrock of what I see as activist literacies. You couldn't stop it if you wanted to. I had never read Maria Stewart's "Why Sit Ye Here and Die?" as a lens into the racial politics of teaching and learning at a PWI. The students did that work without needing my guidance. I was their follow-through, but not their catalyst. The work of anticolonial pedagogy—as antiracist content, non-patriarchal instructional style, anti-ableist structuring, and an anti-western approach to textual design—is the work of writing/rhetoric/composition classrooms. An anticolonial pedagogy is even more immediately "application-based" than how we often think of "vocational" or "skills-based" learning, because an anticolonial pedagogy is a lens through which students are unseeing, acting against, undoing, and talking/writing back to the deliberate organization of their white, neoliberalist learning and lives. Such students are the "decolonial riders" of our discipline.



## **The Fatal Workings of White Solidarity in Writing Programs**

Centering students as “decolonial riders” alongside their activist literacies means, first and foremost, trusting undergraduates. Students are most often interrogated as if they are criminals by compliance officers while faculty call them naïve and denigrate them even further if their criticisms don’t emanate from a language and posture rooted in a white affect. The dispositions of many faculty do not register to BIPOC students as critical of inequity and unfairness, because their white solidarity compromises BIPOC trust. Breaking up with institutional white solidarity is certainly risky, especially when it is so much easier to remain silent or only challenge and question BIPOC faculty and administrators (a tactless practice for both white and non-white folx at universities). I’m old skool Hip Hop though, just like my gurl, Haven, so I uphold the tradition of artists like Whodini. I ain’t looking for racist and/or compromised friends at a racist institution so I know to my core: “Couldn’t trust her with cheese, let alone your keys/ With friends like that you don’t need enemies.”

Because my faculty position where I met Haven came with a distinguished title, I often received emails from undergraduate students who I had never met with complaints about their writing classes. At first, I assumed that they did not understand the administrative organization of the department and were reaching out based on a naïve mistake. It didn’t take me long to challenge my own thinking there. Between my image, title, and biographical description, they were reaching out quite intentionally. I even retained my own legal counsel on when, where, and why I might need to report an instance when students shared things with me that needed to be escalated. Because students’ complaints were coming at me so rapid-fire, I needed some critical context to avoid getting caught up in the willful, illegal ignoring of basic compliance that was all around me. When you must keep a lawyer on retainer based on what students share with you while most faculty just ignore all of it, something is very very wrong.

Turning my solidarity toward students like Haven isn’t a difficult choice because my own fate is nested with hers. Her anger at the “educational withholding of Black Rhetoric and Black Language” alongside her formidable critique of DEI initiatives is not a request for more diversity hires. It is an indictment of institutions and the disciplines and actors who maintain and replicate social inequity. Deracinated curriculum is not an accident; it must be deliberately and actively maintained so that it can sacrifice students like Haven who are granted no place in the university for a deep, meaningful,

Black intellectual life.

As a case in point, a few rhet-comp faculty at Haven's university once contended that a past hire was promised to them in cultural rhetorics, but a committee erased a real focus on cultural rhetorics in the job ad. The literature and creative writing faculty, of course, denied the allegation and saw the critique as misguided. I was not on the faculty then and so had no idea what happened. When I finally read the job ad, I was stunned by its incoherence and inability to name cultural rhetorics given the ways faculty claimed the ad was so excellent and inclusive of the discipline:

The English Department invites applications for a tenure-track position in Black Studies (African American, Africana, and/or Cultural Rhetorics). Rank open. We are a department that values diversity, interdisciplinary research and teaching in ethnic studies, women and gender studies, and the intersections of literature, technology, rhetoric, and writing. We seek scholars with a sustained research agenda, a strong commitment to undergraduate and graduate teaching, and the desire to join colleagues in contributing to new programs in critical race and ethnic studies and African American & Africana studies.

Adding on "cultural rhetorics" last in a parenthesis that lists things that are nonequivalent and that are all supposed to be synonymous with Black Studies is nasty work. My confusion was further confounded by the fact that there was never a Black studies department or major (and the off-and-on minor was minimally supported). It's hard to tell what this job even is. The relatively new ethnic studies department had three tenure-track faculty members (some with spouses on campus) when I arrived and is now gone. The word "critical" in critical race and ethnic studies was changed to "comparative," because the bogeyman of critical race theory was already alive and well—and this was way before the Conservative Right fully appropriated its meaning. The few brave souls who critiqued this ad were right: this is not a public presentation that imagines Black Rhetorics/cultural rhetorics scholars as an audience or that addresses the exploitation of Black scholarship and praxis. Haven could have written a better job ad that included cultural rhetorics in just her second week of class, but calling the department a place that values "diversity" would have been absolutely diabolical for her. It's an all-around hot mess, no matter how you slice it.

The real clincher came when a white rhet-comp faculty member apolo-

gized to members of the department for wrongly accusing them of erasing cultural rhetorics and this is exactly what I mean by the lure and romance of white solidarity. In my mind, the faculty member should have been apologizing instead to every single BIPOC-focused scholar in the discipline, the founders and main practitioners of cultural rhetorics, for: 1) not knowing how to even name and describe their work with just one sentence, too busy bowing down to senior white colleagues instead; and 2) drawing up an exploitative job ad where a Black Studies colleague would be contractually obligated to one department but also designing and supporting another (all with one paycheck and one appointment) and then saying and doing nothing when it is disbanded. It should be obvious that it takes an inordinate amount of work and strain to get a university to value the college literacies of rigorous reading + intensive writing + digital content creation + multimodal design and support the components of what I see as today's comprehensive writing program: summer "bridge" courses, undergraduate writing program, writing across the curriculum, writing/rhetoric minor and major, writing center, PhD program in rhetoric/writing. It takes even more grinding and outright revolt to maintain a comprehensive writing program that simultaneously challenges the white supremacist indoctrination that college writing has always represented in the United States. I question the commitment to the equal humanity/language/literacy of all if the Black-focused hire must support and rally such writing program work while also designing and helping a whole other department elsewhere on a campus with so woefully few Black faculty. Is the goal to work Black rhetoric-compositionists to death in a program that has never addressed whiteness and racism? Or is the goal to divorce Black studies from the writing program by making its researcher/practitioners in rhetoric do their politics elsewhere? Of course, this particular university and example are not an anomaly since the field's white-washed job ads try to target BIPOC in similar ways. These are not innocent mistakes though. These are the results of allying solely with whiteness and sacrificing the BIPOC-centered scholarship and praxis that has always been right there for the taking in rhetoric-composition studies.

It was as if just mentioning the two words, cultural rhetorics, in this job ad was enough to be awe-inspiring, worthy of deep gratitude, and emblematic of deep inclusion. This might explain why many years after Haven graduated, the suggestion that the undergraduate major be changed from "Writing" to "Cultural Rhetorics, Writing, and Design (CRWD)" was met with resistance from the longest-standing white rhet-comp faculty: wealthy parents wouldn't like it (euphemism for only white parents though, not the

kind of folx who raised Haven); students are not attracted to rhetoric; there are no appeals to the job market, especially publishing; no one on the planet has ever heard of rhetoric; and on and on. And then, there was my favorite excuse and coinage of all: AUDIENCE. At this point, audience is just a screen for folx who won't unravel western conventions and decenter whiteness. Meanwhile, at this time: the existing major only attracted 33 students out of an undergraduate student population of 10,000+ students; I spent hours mentoring the FEW disabled, queer, first-generation, BIPOC, community-college transfers, and/or working-class majors in my advising cohort who all complained about the violence of classroom experiences in their required courses; and first and second-year students in my own rhetoric/writing classes (with a class size of 35—which was, ironically, bigger than the major) had already been turned off from the field based on comp and comp II classes they had taken. This is an undergraduate major that appealed to less than .33% of students. Since that's not even half of 1%, it seems there might be some audience problems here. The white rhetorics of the mainstream offerings of the major (titles, sequence, content, purposing) aren't working to attract even a mostly white student population. White students are often merely a convenient scapegoat for white faculty's fear and race-evasion. The educational withholding that Haven so adamantly criticized goes from the job ad to the construction of the major.

Even though white solidarity can get you caught out there on real dumb mess, it remains a siren song. Word on the street is that when I was hired for one of the university positions that I have held, one white faculty member expressed her deep concern about what it would do to their department if someone like me was a member. This is a type of prevalent department talk at colleges where there is no collective of older Black professors, especially Black women professors, who have worked across institutions at the level of tenure for many years (because the university hired no BIPOC faculty in the 20th century). White interlocutors haven't had multiple opportunities to have their racism publicly read for filth by a critical body of senior Black faculty and so have lived a life of unchecked, public, racist discourse in their departments. To this faculty member's dismay and many others, I got the job. By the time I arrived, this more vocal person was an administrator at the helm where less than six months after my arrival, a race-based discrimination lawsuit indicting the department came through. It seems like she was worried about the wrong person and the wrong thing and at the wrong time. She had much bigger fish to fry. I ain't never been the one hauled off for depositions in court, ain't never co-signed folx who

are, and ain't never let that kind of stuff go down on my watch when I was administering any program. All I could do was shake my head and move on. Like I said, they just get caught out there! As Melaku and Beeman have shown in their qualitative study of the experiences of BIPOC women in academia during and after the crises of COVID-19 and national protests against anti-black profiling and police murders, Black women's constant managing of racial/gender aggression is considered part of the job requirement. When antiracism in neoliberal institutions is limited, at best, to liberalist pity for BIPOC suffering and refuses material risk and psychic divestment of whiteness, it replicates institutional racism rather than challenges it.

It should come as no surprise that, as of this date, Haven and her close friends were the last mass of Black students in the writing/rhetoric major. In fact, in the fall semester directly following white resistance to changing the major from "Writing" to "Cultural Rhetorics, Writing, and Design (CRWD)," numbers in the major plummeted even more. Meanwhile, the number of Latine students at the university had steadily increased, almost doubling in the past ten years. The same cannot be said of the major. Like Haven's Black peers, her Latine friends have now also graduated, with only three Latine students now in the major (and likely also graduating soon). It is not as simple as scapegoating the general enrollment trends of a PWI. Across thirteen years, the major struggled to keep up with the institution's diversity and has never achieved it. This PWI is thus more diverse than the major. The major is not a microcosm of the PWI's whiteness; it is whiter. The required Comp I and Comp II are obviously also implicated here. With two required courses for all students at the university, taught by the same people who teach in the major and minor, not even 1% of the student population stay with us, and not one single Black student is compelled enough by Comp I or Comp II to pursue this major or minor. After tracing the patterns of Black and Latine major enrollments across the university, they are equally, if not more so, interested in the social sciences and humanities than STEM. It's only this college's version of writing and rhetoric that does not appeal to them. These facts are not surprising when, despite the increase in hiring of BIPOC faculty, no change or even conversation about curriculum has happened. It reminds me of what James Sledd would call "boss compositionists," who "maintain and defend the indefensible while tinkering with an iniquitous system just enough to obscure its iniquities but never enough to change it deeply" (147). It is the same white content, just repackaged from the mouths of BIPOC folk, that doesn't even attract many white students. There is no need for writing programs to lament the "anti-DEI" moves of the administration, state, or

nation when the track record looks like this.

It is truly a wonder that any university would allow a writing and rhetoric major to operate this way and never even ask for a program-wide assessment of Comp I and Comp II. No program, however, could achieve these levels of Black and Brown displacement and ethnic cleansing without large departmental and college-wide, even if benevolent, consent. At the time of this writing, Brown and Black children were chronically absent in K-12 schools. David Kirkland traces these issues at forwardedED in “Where Have Our Children Gone? Chronic Absenteeism and the Disappearance of Black, Latinx, and Economically Less Advantaged Students Post-COVID.” Kirkland shares that in places like New York City, chronic absenteeism after COVID rose from 27 percent in 2019 to over 40 percent in 2022, especially impacting working-class/working-poor BIPOC students. Meanwhile, in places like Los Angeles, absenteeism among Black students in fall of 2024 was at 57 percent while districts across the U.S. reported absenteeism spikes (Blume). As Kirkland argues, this absence of BIPOC students sits at the amalgamation of multiple forces: administrative failures; schools’ disconnection from students’ lives; refusals to meet the needs of the most vulnerable populations; social inequities related to housing, hunger, and trauma; lack of safety in schools; ongoing inability to offer a sense of belonging and identity affirmation for BIPOC, queer students, and disabled students; hostility and disregard from a still-too-white teaching force. It is not a coincidence that while K-12 schools have been purging Black students, our writing program was doing the same. I was the only person who noticed and only a few others even expressed alarm.

Haven has maintained not just herself but a deep critique of these spaces in her writing and in her persuasive appeals to her classmates, all with a Black visual and multimodal creative flair, and all with Black Language wisdoms fully in tow. When you consider all the ways institutions co-sign racist everyday life, we must see the work that Haven has done pushing her thinking beyond the models assigned to her as activist literacies. After all, Haven finished a program and system of schooling that was quite literally trying to remove her. Nothing in the academic life of her university or writing program is designed with her in mind and yet she has constructed a rich Black counterlife right up in it anyway. That’s a helluva thing that, quite honestly, most faculty struggle to achieve in a racist academy.

## **Racism—The Real Reason Why Rhetoric-Composition Studies Won't Stand Alone**

Early in my career as a compositionist, my colleagues who did literary theory didn't understand how I, as a rhet-comp scholar, was making connections to cultural studies. I don't really label my work this way, but this is what they said, nonetheless. I've always found these monikers problematic, because it resuscitates a 1990s racist binary between those who look at race/gender/social issues as cultural studies (i.e., BIPOC) vs. those who just do "Literature" (i.e., white people who represent the "real" discipline). I do consider myself intellectually raised by the who's who of folk often connected to cultural studies like Stuart Hall, bell hooks, Gayatri Spivak, Walter Benjamin, and Antonio Gramsci (Dworkin; Morley and Chen; Hall). However, I have always just called myself and my work Black: Black Theory/ Black Feminist/ Black Intellectual/ Black Radical Tradition. Black. The compositionists in that department were quick to tell me about the literature faculty's concerns, but they never shared how they challenged their colleagues' thinking. Because they didn't. And never have. With cultural studies as a field of study that examines expressions of power and social structures in relation to class, ethnicity, gender, race, ideology, sexuality, and nationality, it is indeed sad that no one could understand or defend how cultural studies might relate to schools, literacy, and learning. It sure would have helped the compositionists at that institution understand their department better.

Just a few weeks into the job, as a still-young assistant professor, I felt a real uncomfortable tension between rhet-comp and literature faculty, with the creative writing folks stuck in the middle pretending to stay neutral (but really on the side of literature—I'll just keep it 100% about that cuz it is what it is). I shared my unease with a rhet-comp colleague, and she told me that it was just me, that the literature faculty felt estranged from my work and so kept a distance. In contrast, she described her own wonderful relationship with all the faculty in the department across all the subfields. She denied there was any beef in the department and acted like I didn't know what I was talking about. As the only Black member of the department, she sympathized with me feeling alone, but there were no tensions in the department. Today, I simply refer to this person as someone out of her everlasting mind. Even if it were true that only the Black person was strained, that's still evidence of some tension. But. . . but. . . but. . . that literary faculty hated her, tried to block her tenure, and thought her work was an intellectual sham. Still do. They tolerated me (a compliment since I was a compositionist) but they

talked about her like a dogg and regularly too. She was none the wiser. It wasn't like they were phony about it. They were never particularly pleasant. It's not like I didn't have beef with her too, like when she would do offensive things like suggest graduate students not read about HBCUs because those weren't inclusive programs. Yeah, she said that. Out loud. To a whole class with Black graduate students in it. Ironically, the disdain for rhet-comp seemed obvious to everyone but her.

Folx at the college talked real reckless about rhet-comp, the writing center, and the writing program faculty, whenever and however they wanted. And girlfriend really had no clue. Her own whiteness prevented her from a real analysis of the department, from ever imagining her own marginalization, and from going upside people's heads the way she needed to. Things never got better.

These extreme lengths that folx will travel in a department or program to insist that everything is nice-and-gravy also sustain racism and white comfort. This gets represented as a forced insistence that everyone gets along and is doing the same kind of work, oftentimes with a kind of conservative, white mantra like #AllLivesMatter whose main goal is to silence the specificity of Black/BIPOC protest (Garza). For instance, so many English department faculty, especially chairs, have foolishly said things like *everyone here is a writing teacher* or *we all do rhetoric*. I have yet to get an answer to my follow-up questions: *then why do yall suck so bad at it? And how yall manage to ignore all the theory and praxis from the last 50 years?* Just foolishness: condescending and submediocre at the same time. In this deranged utopia, all sides of the department will construct racial critique as illogical, inaccurate, mean, disruptive, emotional, divisive, harsh, non-collegial, prejudicial, toxic, obstructionist. I provide this long list of words since these racist stereotypes have all been used to describe me at some point, especially 100+ year old universities who haven't hired BIPOC faculty until the 21st century. Since no one knows much about or speaks up for actual, current rhet-comp theory and praxis, white-settler histories and racist labels live on and on.

In many spaces, rhetoric-composition faculty are still heavily outnumbered or have been otherwise repressed in ways that folx might whisper about but never fully analyze. Rhet-comp faculty sometimes represent themselves in such instances with a holier-than-thou martyrdom or missionary self-righteousness. In this masquerade, majoritarian compositionists often act as if they are too incapacitated to address racial injustice or their own disciplinary marginalization. Because #SchoolSoWhite has benefitted whitestream compositionists, even across various other marginalized-while-white social



locations, it is sometimes unfathomable and deeply painful to be so casually regarded as intellectually inferior. I don't expect to be intellectually respected or listened to in the academy as a Black feminist, so I don't get surprised by everyday, routine white supremacy, so I can't relate. Being a compositionist is the least of my denigrations. Racism is never addressed in these martyrdom-convictions, if it is even noticed, and so racism, racialized self-pity, and white dominance just live on and on.

And if that wasn't enough, many of the literary faculty have worked very hard to locate the racism of the department on the rhet-comp faculty's backs. Graduate students, desperately trying to escape teaching the denigrated first-year writing course that fuels departments' budgets and schedules, often fall right in line. Unfortunately, and yet typically, so many rhet-comp faculty stay silent to get along with everyone. I don't have that affliction, so I insist: only a true dumbass who knows nothing about the history of higher education would think that the white racial violence of an English department or School of Liberal Arts anytime or anywhere is the design and fault of a small, disregarded set of rhet-comp faculty in its midst. The math just ain't mathin. I mean, do these folx not read anything at all and just bypass all them books in the library? Big ol' library just sitting right there and got folx walkin right on past? Ain't nobody thought to go in and investigate such claims about the racial history of higher education before talking like they know?

These issues seem like they would catalyze most rhetoric-compositionists to form their own department, but that is rarely the case. I blame whiteness for this, since so many majoritarian compositionists seem to prefer the canonical cover of the longstanding white supremacy and privilege in the age-old English department rather than the self-reckoning work they would need to do in a free-standing rhetoric-composition department. My indictment of whiteness here is not hyperbolic, but part of a theoretical thread in Black studies 100 years in the making (King). Most notably, W. E. B. DuBois chronicled in his 1935 work, *Black Reconstruction in America*, America's transformative Black activism after emancipation and the immediate, white racist backlash to it. In that chronicling, he posited whiteness as its own psychic reward that prevented white working-class/white poor folx from connecting their oppression to Black masses: even if they were literally starving, at least they weren't Black. David Roediger's now infamous 1991 book and phrase, "the wages of whiteness," were directly built from DuBois's *Black Reconstruction*. Both texts challenged traditionalist Marxist thought that argued that racism disappears once capitalism vanishes because the psycho-

logical coveting of whiteness keeps white people from allying with BIPOC and overthrowing their class oppression. This extant literature challenges any notion that critiques of the “possessive investment in whiteness” (Lip-sitz) are new and implicates the reading list and theoretical understanding of scholars who have ignored 100 years of DuBois and 30+ years of popular scholars like Roediger. Drawing from these theories of labor and whiteness, I contend that many white colleagues, to their own detriment, prefer the “wages of whiteness” afforded in English departments and from their white faculty peers to the activism of BIPOC rhet-comp researchers and the equally maligned BIPOC student writers demanding a different university. For many compositionists, whether they acknowledge their disciplinary marginalization or ignore it, their analyses and responses are often tethered to their desire to still maintain their white privilege.

When it all falls down, what does all this mean? These are the contexts in which undergraduate students like Haven must further compose college literacy and writing at our colleges. The presence of any BIPOC student who designs, writes, speaks, and imagines from the cultural and linguistic locations of marginalized and/or racially subordinated BIPOC communities is an act of soaring imagination and radicality, because there is so little in writing programs and English departments that creates such pockets of air for this kind of decolonial rider (Reed).

### **Earthworms, Air Pockets, Pandemics, and BIPOC Creation**

I have had a Haven in every college class that I have taught since I began college teaching in 1998. “Decolonial riders” like Haven take up a race-radical and theoretically informed opposition and make it popular in the classroom. Students like her have certainly created air pockets akin to the ecological magic of earthworms. They move far beyond the political or legal patterns of when/if/how the United States recognizes diverse identities. In contrast, the DEI platforms and liberal humanisms that have shaped Haven’s college education might have been abhorred by the anti-black violence against her, but it was always an abhorrence without consequence, free from political responsibility, and devoid of real acknowledgement of systemic grievances. Haven understands that she must instead design and reimagine her humanity, objectification, and commodification since her Black “enfleshment” is always object, machine, and unfeeling (Weheliye). Such literacies create what Fred Moten calls a rich “Black topological existence” where Black designers make and preserve alternate spaces under duress. Such Black literate design

also creates entirely different memories of and relationships in classrooms.

Haven and I only got to spend half a semester together face-to-face. By the time spring break came, we were in a full-blown pandemic under COVID lockdowns. Like students across the country, Haven was sent back home to finish out the semester online while wondering what difference school would make if this was truly the apocalypse. After a few days of online teaching mayhem at my college, I knew it was time to revise the course with Haven and her classmates. Some of the students wanted to keep engaging with the content; others were just too overwhelmed for many reasons. These reactions fell along racial lines, so I offered two choices. First option: students who wanted/needed to check out could end the class with a PASS but promise to update me regularly letting me know they were okay and makin it somehow. Second option: students could still learn the content of the course but do so at a slower and different pace and automatically get an A for the class—no pressure, just Black rhetoric and language content in multimedia ways. All the BIPOC students of color and the most radical white allies opted to continue with the content. The rest of the students opted for a PASS and sent me regular email updates, some of which were more like absolutely entertaining journal entries of various escapades with things like burning a souffle. Not all updates were happy, but we got through. I created a discussion board housed on the course website out of view of the university and did some asynchronous and synchronous activities around Black Language and rhetoric. One online discussion got really charged after someone posted: “These professors really took their problematic and dispassionate content from the physical room to zoom and are trying to make the pandemic worse! So many know nothing about technology, and it shows.” After that, I eased up all analog writing and offered multimodal options. When it seemed like students were sinking with deadlines in their other classes that did not translate analog teaching to the digital or to the pandemic, I offered hand-made options that could be snail-mailed to me or photographed. It seemed like hand-crafted projects might help toward some self-care for students who were navigating (and becoming more alienated by) heavy print-based assignments via online learning management systems and in the context of global trauma at that! For those first two months of the pandemic lockdown after spring break, I met regularly online with a group of BIPOC students of color and critical, white allies who posted, emailed, and snail-mailed me some of the most dynamic, creative work I have ever seen in response to Black Rhetoric and Language, a lot of which hangs now in my campus office, including, and especially, works by Haven. We called

it the Corona Remix Cypher. Some weeks, I would go to my mailbox, find student projects there, and an explosion of glitter would erupt right there in my hands and all over the front porch. It was amazing.

Haven lived off-campus and near me, so she would sometimes walk over to the house I was renting, and we would talk across the lawn of my front yard. She couldn't break her lease, so she was waiting for a few months into the summer before she would leave the city for her next destination. We didn't really coordinate anything, but when the mailbox opened or the doorbell rang, we would chitchat outside. After those lawn chats with Haven and the larger Corona Remix Cypher, I understood even better how students work as "decolonial riders" and design alternative spaces. I have lived in and survived because of their spaces.

Life was really life-ing for me before COVID lockdowns, and the pandemic made it worse. In the year prior to the pandemic, my mother's cancer returned with a vengeance. My mother was "my person," as people like to say today, and for twelve months, I was her sole caretaker across multiple bouts of chemo-radiation, numerous seizures, and two strokes during a new job in a new city and new state far away from my family and friends. In March 2020, at the official onset of the pandemic, I was trained in and began hospice services for my mother in my home. Because the rapid spread of the virus at that time meant I would not be able to visit or see her if she had been admitted to a facility, I did hospice caretaking for her alone. Now four years later, I only remember two things: all the exchanges with students in that Black Rhetoric and Language class and my own hospice caretaking of my mother in her final weeks and days. I must have cooked at that time, since I certainly gained weight, but I have no recollection of this. I vaguely recollect the 2020 Great Toilet Paper Shortage but must have managed something since I never ran out. I must have bought groceries and taken care of household chores, because no one else helped me with that, but I can't recall any of that either. When my mother finally passed in late spring, I moved to a different home because I couldn't bear the memories of the one where I had done hospice. I certainly must have packed and hired movers. I must have even unpacked a lot of stuff too, because I managed to fill a three-story Texas townhouse all on my own. I have no single memory of any of it. I only remember the intimate process of my mother's dying. And I only remember those students who chose to create a learning and giving community in that moment and included me in it.

As it turns out, in true ancestral heritage, Black Language and rhetoric are an open door to getting through all the pains and joys that life will throw

at you. Black Language and rhetoric let you get it all down in words, onto the page, into the design, and out in the world too when your “soul looks back in wonder at how you got ovuh”! And while most of my memory loss undoubtedly comes from the trauma of losing my mother while forced to quarantine alone, that moment changed me, my teaching, and my convictions around decolonizing the anti-humanity of schooling in new ways. Any patience and graciousness for white complicity that I may have once held is completely gone. After all, I endured the greatest loss of my life in a global health crisis that forced me to do it alone. Nothing could get worse than that, so why should I give undeserving breathing room to white supremacy and its two-faced practitioners? Since the worst has already happened to me, white supremacy is lightweight work. I don’t intend to be nice about it.

“Decolonial riders” created pockets of air in my classrooms during an epidemic that quite literally attacked breathing and respiration. That symbolism and materiality are worth noting. These are entire other-worlds that match the kind of miraculousness that I have learned from earthworms where care, learning, unrelenting critique, and creative play move us toward alternative pathways and renewed life. Indeed, our discipline could be transformed with this kind of purpose and praxis. I’m tired of waiting for that though. In the meantime, I’m rolling out with my “decolonial riders” to the places that only they will go.

## **Acknowledgments**

I extend my deepest gratitude to Dhipinder Walia and Anna Zeemont for their brilliant revision suggestions, deep care, and political support of this writing. You are my earthworms.

## **Notes**

1. Methodological note: I have changed this student’s name to Haven, even though the student is not requesting anonymity. If this essay is read by faculty in the attending department, faculty could easily identify who this student is, even if I only offer her first name. Some faculty might reach out to her for further discussion and lunch from the place of white guilt rather than desire for real change, further taxing Haven’s time, mind, and energy. The combination of white liberalist anxiety, arrogance, and racism involves a complete non-understanding that reaching out to Haven in this day-late/dollar-too-short kinda way would be an act of racist, carceral surveillance, not compassion and commit-

ment to doing better. After all, the possibility of doing better with Black folx has been available for hundreds of years now. I call this fugitive naming. I want to do more than follow the general rule of qualitative/human-subjects research of anonymizing research participants. Haven is not anonymous; narrating her deep critiques of the university while providing a modicum of safety from the white university that harmed her is the fugitive politics of my writing. The name HAVEN is a rhyming combination of the arc of names this student's family calls her. Haven is also a name where she and hers will easily recognize themselves. As always, not all of what she and students shared has been divulged in this essay since some stuff ain't nobody's bid'ness but our own.

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